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‘Access for All’ or ‘Only for Some’: How Creativity Shapes Public Spaces Through Accessible vs. Hostile Design

Danish architect and urban design consultant Jan Gehl once wrote, “First we shape the cities - then they shape us.” Public spaces influence how individuals experience the world, and the creative decisions behind the designs of these spaces play a significant role in determining who feels welcomed or excluded. Designing public spaces involves the contrasting philosophies between accessible and hostile design. Accessible design (also called “inclusive design” and “universal design”) is founded on design strategies that promote inclusivity, ensuring public spaces are welcoming and functional for people of all abilities. On the other hand, hostile design (also known as “exclusive design” or “defensive architecture”) incorporates design techniques to control how people use public spaces, thereby deterring behaviour deemed undesirable by designers or property owners.

Creativity in public space design can serve different purposes—promoting inclusivity through accessible design or fostering exclusion via hostile design. We can explore how creative thinking shapes public spaces by analyzing the intentions behind these designs, their societal impact, and their ethical implications. These spaces can become welcoming, functional

environments that accommodate diverse needs or tools for imposing control, regulating behaviour, and excluding marginalized groups, reflecting broader societal values and priorities.

INTENTIONS BEHIND DESIGN

The intentions behind public space design reveal the underlying philosophies that guide creative decisions. These intentions can either foster inclusivity or reinforce exclusion, shaping the experiences of various users. Understanding the motivations that drive accessible design and hostile design provides insight into how creativity can be wielded for both positive and negative societal outcomes.

Intentions behind accessible design. Accessible design, guided by the 7 Principles of Universal Design, aims to create environments that are usable by all people and accommodate diverse needs (Mace et al. 1). The guiding principles—such as equitable use, flexibility, and simplicity—ensure accessibility for everyone, not just individuals with disabilities. The creative philosophy behind accessible design seeks to eliminate barriers that prevent individuals from fully participating in everyday activities, considering “the full range of human diversity with respect to ability...and other forms of human difference” (Costanza-Chock 53-54). For instance, urban design features like ramps and automatic doors benefit not only wheelchair users but also those with strollers or delivery carts. Accessible design is driven by a commitment to creating environments that promote independence and equal opportunity for all, encouraging designers to think critically about how to cater to a variety of needs and abilities.

Intentions behind hostile design. In hostile design, creativity is applied with a different mindset—one that prioritizes controlling how public spaces are used and restricting certain behaviours often associated with marginalized groups. This design approach can be constructed

by modifying existing infrastructure, adding elements to deter a space's possible uses, and eliminating objects to remove certain functions (de Fine Licht 29). The design philosophy it is derived from, which is crime prevention through environmental design (CPTED), has the objective of preventing crime or protecting property through surveillance, control, and enforcement (Chellew 18). Hence, these creative choices are usually driven by concerns over safety, security, aesthetics, or property values, but they often reflect a lack of empathy for marginalized groups. Creativity in this context is all about subtle exclusion and enforcing behavioural norms.

The contrasting intentions behind accessible and hostile design reveal the complexities of creative decision-making in public space design as they are fundamentally opposed, reflecting different priorities in how public spaces and environments are shaped. While accessible design seeks to include and empower all individuals, hostile design exercises exclusion and control, highlighting how the same creative tools can be employed for fundamentally different purposes depending on the designer's intent and the needs they prioritize.

IMPACT ON SOCIETY

Another significant aspect of both accessible and hostile design is their impact on society. The impact of public space design extends beyond the individual user experience to influence broader societal dynamics. Accessible and hostile designs shape social interactions, community cohesion, and the overall quality of urban life, revealing how creativity can either build bridges or establish barriers.

Impact of accessible design on society. Accessible design creates inclusive, adaptable, and equitable environments, enhancing social interaction by allowing people of all abilities to

participate fully in public life. This design approach and “its seven guiding principles...places users at the heart of the design, planning and policy-making process” (Afacan and Afacan 94; Mace et al. 1). It ensures that public spaces are not only functional but also reflective of a society that values of equity and inclusion. As such, accessible design fosters a sense of belonging, breaking down barriers that would otherwise marginalize individuals based on ability, age, or other differences; it creates a ripple effect in society, encouraging broader acceptance of diversity and promoting a culture of inclusivity.

Impact of hostile design on society. Hostile design significantly impacts societal structures by shaping human behaviour in public spaces to reflect values of exclusion and control. As Crippen and Klement observed, "design is value-sensitive and has social implications that organize human behaviour", and hostile design is a clear example of this (463). Through altering the function and accessibility of public spaces, hostile design affects more than just marginalized groups; it "utterly change[s] the nature of public furniture from an invitation for interaction" (Kive 692). "Anti-homeless" benches, for instance, limit seating and diminish opportunities for spontaneous social encounters. The creative choices in hostile design often result in uninviting and unattractive public spaces, making them less welcoming and more selective about who can use them, thereby contributing to a culture that stigmatizes certain behaviours or groups.

The contrasting societal impacts of accessible and hostile design highlight their significant roles in shaping public interaction and communal experiences within spaces. These design choices reflect broader societal values, influencing how spaces are used and who feels welcome in them. While accessible design fosters inclusivity and enhances public life for all, hostile design creates division and alienation, underscoring the power of creativity in shaping

these environments and the need for intentional, thoughtful design decisions that prioritize inclusivity.

ETHICAL IMPLICATIONS

Having discussed the contrasting intentions and impacts of accessible and hostile design, the final section of this paper addresses the moral consequences of these approaches, emphasizing how the ethical implications of design choices are critical in understanding the responsibilities of designers in shaping societal values. Both accessible and hostile designs raise important questions about equity and dignity, highlighting the role of creativity in promoting inclusivity or perpetuating exclusion.

Ethical implications of accessible design. The ethical implications of accessible design are deeply rooted in the principles of equity, dignity, and social justice. While primarily focused on inclusivity, accessible design does not aim to limit creative possibilities or adhere to strict guidelines. As Costanza-Chock explains, “design justice doesn’t imply that we must somehow reduce our options to only those that satisfy all accessibility criteria for the most marginalized...but rather as a prism through which to generate a far wider rainbow of possible choices” (229-230). This framework encourages designers to create solutions tailored to the specific needs of different communities, rather than imposing a one-size-fits-all approach. It highlights the ethical responsibility of designers to think expansively about how their work can cater to diverse groups, reinforcing the idea that creativity in accessible design can enrich public spaces by reflecting the values and needs of various populations.

Ethical implications of hostile design. Hostile design raises significant concerns regarding social responsibility and human dignity. As Kive asserts, “hostile design is in part a reflection of the

prevailing social values and cultural perceptions, [but] design plays a significant role in defining who has access to the public space, what it affords them, and how it disciplines them" (691).

These design choices raise serious ethical questions about whose needs are prioritized and how power is exercised through space. Designers who implement such features face ethical dilemmas—are they complicit in perpetuating inequality, or are they simply responding to societal pressures for safety and order? This complexity needs a careful examination of the societal impacts and moral justifications for such design choices, challenging the idea that creativity in public space design can be used solely for the betterment of the community.

The ethical considerations surrounding accessible and hostile design underscore the far-reaching influence creative decisions have on shaping societal values. Accessible design embodies a commitment to inclusivity and equity, reflecting a moral responsibility to create environments that support and empower all individuals. In contrast, hostile design challenges these principles, raising concerns about the exclusion of marginalized groups and the broader social implications of prioritizing control over inclusivity.

CONCLUSION

Creativity and creative thinking in public space design dictate the functionality, accessibility, and ethics of these spaces, influencing how communities interact and who is included or excluded. Public spaces reflect societal values and creative decisions play a key role in determining whether these spaces promote inclusivity, dignity, and equity or perpetuate division and alienation. Designers, architects, and urban planners must grapple with the ethical consequences of their creative decisions, recognizing that their choices not only influence how public spaces are used but also shape the broader societal values that these spaces reflect.

Whether fostering belonging or enforcing exclusion, these design choices affect not only the functionality of environments but also the inclusivity or divisiveness of our communities. As public spaces continue to evolve, designers and policymakers must prioritize inclusivity, ensuring that creativity in design serves the common good rather than perpetuating inequality.

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